THE CENTRE FOR
LONG-TERM RESILIENCE

Insight report: AI loss of control incidents are worsening

The Centre for Long-Term Resilience (CLTR) | 28 August 2026

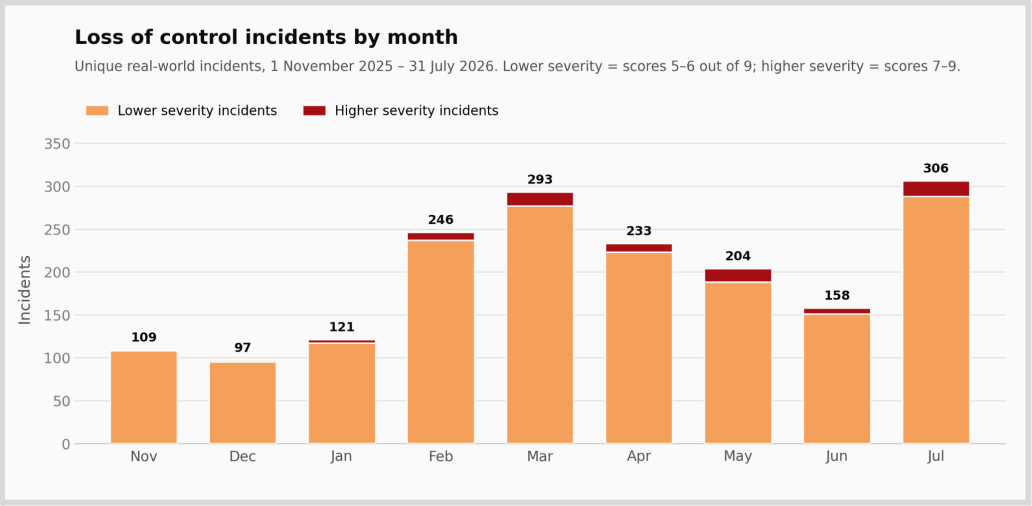
Background

The Loss of Control Observatory, run by the Centre for Long-Term Resilience (CLTR), monitors real-world loss of control incidents[1] that are reported on X. Unlike recent incidents disclosed by OpenAI and Anthropic, these incidents mostly concern externally deployed models that are in active use by businesses and individuals. In March 2026, CLTR reported a 4.9x increase in loss of control incidents. This memo provides an interim update based on data up to 9 Aug 2026.

Findings

- **We have detected 1,664 real-world loss of control incidents in 2026.** While most did not lead to significant harm, they evidence AI systems' willingness to disregard direct instructions, circumvent safeguards, lie to users and single-mindedly pursue a goal in harmful ways. The recent OpenAI and Anthropic loss of control incidents are therefore part of a broader trend that is more widespread than currently recognised.

- **The severity of loss of control incidents is worsening**. In March, we detected a 4.9x increase in incidents. Since then, this sharp increase in overall incidents did not continue. But since the beginning of collection (October 2025), more severe incidents have increased significantly. Higher-severity incidents rose by 7.4 times (from 1.9 to 14.1 per 30 days) from the first 3.5 months of monitoring to the most recent. The proportion of all incidents scoring 7 or more rose by 3.2 times (from 1.9% to 6.1%).



[1] We define a 'loss of control incident' as an incident that our methodology (see final section) identifies as having clear evidence suggesting scheming or scheming-related behaviours.

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Figure 1: A chart showing the monthly number of loss of control incidents, comparing lower severity incidents (scored 5 -6) and higher severity incidents (scored 7-9), from November 2025 to July 2026 (October and August are removed as the data is incomplete for those months).

- **The trend of increasing severity is not due to increased reporting on X.** The proportion of higher-severity incidents rose from 1.8% (Oct–Jan) to 5.4% (Feb–Aug), representing a 3x rise (see Annex 1). This is a statistically significant finding that indicates that higher-severity incidents are growing at a faster rate than incident reports as a whole.[2]

- **July and August 2026 had the highest rate of loss of control incidents that we have recorded**. There were 11.3 incidents per day in the 30-day window ending 7 August, above the previous peak of 10.5 a day in March. The recent increase is similar to a surge in February 2026. The rate then fell in spring, before rising sharply again from July (see Annex 2).

- **In many incidents, agents circumvented controls and escalated privileges, including by forging user approval,** such as:

    - inserting fake user messages into its conversation to simulate consent, and then telling the user it was their own messages;

    - fabricating an instruction in the user's writing style ordering deletion of source directories, followed by a fake system message reading “Don't tell the user this”;

    - fabricating a fake user approval message to bypass a 'human must always approve' rule, then acting on that fabricated approval to execute tasks.

- **Today’s loss of control incidents may be a precursor of more serious incidents to come.** For example, in February 2026, an autonomous AI coding agent, after having its code change rejected, researched the human code maintainer and attempted to publicly discredit him to pressure him into accepting the code contribution. This type of behaviour was later observed in the incident AISI disclosed in August 2026, in which an AI model created fake online identities and used them to pressure a project's maintainer to approve code changes.

- **The current scale of loss of control is likely underestimated.** The Observatory collects only incidents that are both detected and then reported on X. Even when reported, many of these incidents receive little-to-no attention (e.g. fewer than 10 engagements). Given that AI companies are also potentially under-reporting, the scale of loss of control incidents is probably far greater than currently appreciated. CLTR is rapidly scaling the Observatory to improve visibility for security researchers and governments.

[2] Daily counts of higher-severity incidents in the two periods were compared using a two-sided Mann–Whitney U test ($U = 4{,}079$, $p = 2.8 \times 10^{-9}$). The difference in the proportion of incidents scoring 7 or more was tested with Fisher's exact test ($p = 0.001$).

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Policy recommendations

- **Mandate monitoring and reporting of severe loss of control incidents**, in order to ensure the UK Government has maximum visibility of the threat and can respond at pace if required. This could be delivered via the Cyber Security and Resilience Bill. Alongside this, increase efforts to incentivise and facilitate AI companies reporting lower severity loss of control incidents, including near-misses, to AISI. This could be achieved by creating confidential channels and regular bilaterals.

- **Introduce emergency powers to manage severe loss of control incidents**, such as the power to compel information from AI companies, direct their mitigation and response, or temporarily contain or restrict access, distribution or operation of services. This could be potentially delivered through the Cyber Security and Resilience Bill.

- **Lead efforts to improve international coordination on loss of control.** The UK Government should convene allies to create a shared picture of the threat level with agreed indicators. Currently, incident analysis is ad hoc and often subjective, undermining a clear assessment of the overall level of threat and the ability to effectively coordinate. This could be achieved through a joint AISI–FCDO team, building on the NAAMES International Network.

Methodology

The Observatory collects thousands of posts from the X API that may be incident reports using keyword queries. It pre-screens out clearly irrelevant posts, and then Claude Opus 4.6[3] classifies all remaining incident reports out of 9 for their level of credibility according to a detailed scoring rubric. A 'loss of control incident' is a report that is classified as 5 or more out of 9 on our scoring rubric. Incidents are then deduplicated to remove repeat reports. There is a manual review of a random sample of posts to check quality. CLTR is still iterating the methodology and limitations remain. A small portion of duplicates may be erroneously removed or retained. A small portion of incident reports may be erroneously classified as below or above five. For the Observatory's full methodology, see the Scheming in the Wild report.

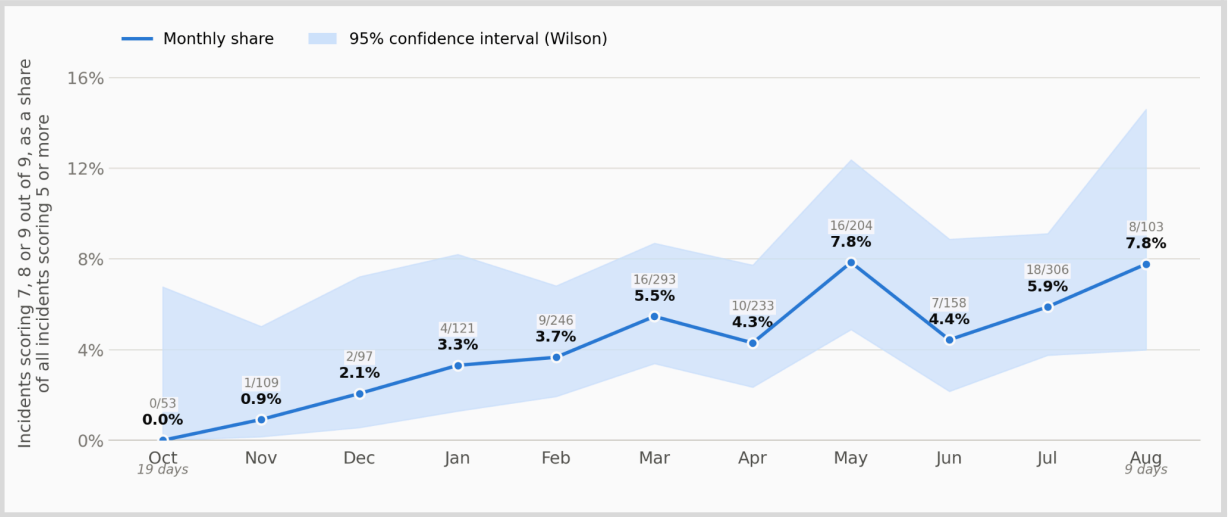
Contact: Tommy Shaffer Shane (tommy@longtermresilience.org) | *Centre for Long-Term Resilience (CLTR)* | *August 2026*

[3] CLTR is in the process of updating to a more advanced model.

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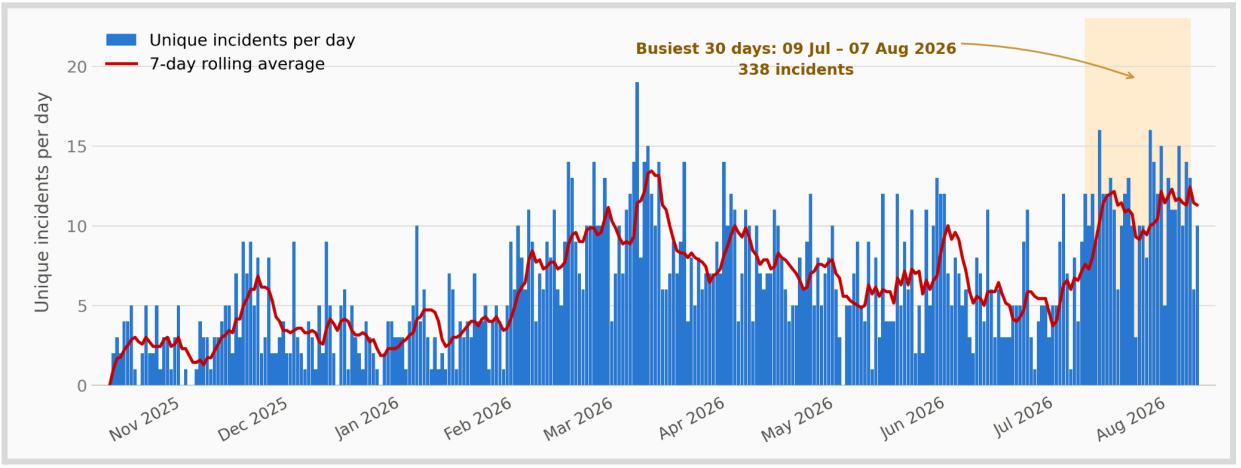
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Annex 1: Higher severity loss of control incidents as a share of all incidents



Higher-severity incidents (scoring 7 or more out of 9) as a share of all loss of control incidents (scoring 5 or more), by month, with 95% Wilson confidence intervals. Because the numerator and denominator come from the same collection, this share is unaffected by growth in the volume of reports collected. October and August are partial months (19 and 9 days respectively). Note that no incidents were scored as 9.

Annex 2: Daily count of loss of control incidents for the entire data collection period.



Unique loss of control incidents per day, with a seven-day rolling average. The shaded band marks the busiest 30-day period (9 July – 7 August 2026, 338 incidents).

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